
Topic 4: Learning theories

Topic overview

Students must show an understanding that learning theories are about learning from the environment and of the effects of conditioning, reinforcement, punishment, the role of reward and social learning on the organism.

Individual differences and developmental psychology must be considered when learning about the effect of rewards and punishment on individuals and how children develop through the different ways of learning, including social learning.

Subject content	What students need to learn:
4.1 Content	Classical conditioning
	4.1.1 The main features of classical conditioning, including: unconditioned stimulus (UCS); unconditioned response (UCR); conditioned stimulus (CS); neutral stimulus (NS); conditioned response (CR); extinction, spontaneous recovery and stimulus generalisation.
	4.1.2 Pavlov (1927) experiment with salivation in dogs.
	Operant conditioning
	4.1.3 The main features of operant conditioning, including: types of reinforcement and punishment (positive and negative).
	4.1.4 Properties of reinforcement, including primary and secondary reinforcement and schedules of reinforcement.
	4.1.5 Behaviour modification, including 'shaping' behaviour.
	4.1.6 The main features of social learning theory, including: observation, imitation, modelling and vicarious reinforcement.
	4.1.7 Social learning 'stages' of attention, retention, reproduction and motivation (reinforcement).
	4.1.8 Bandura (1961, 1963) original Bobo doll experiments.
	4.1.9 Bandura (1965) Bobo doll experiment with vicarious reinforcement.
	4.1.10 How learning theories explain the acquisition and maintenance of phobias.
	4.1.11 Treatments for phobias based on theories of learning, including systematic desensitisation and one other.

Subject content	What students need to learn:
4.1 Content <i>(continued)</i>	4.1.12 Individual differences • How people differ because of different environmental influences and experiences, for example in the form of rewards and punishments and models observed. 4.1.13 Developmental psychology • The idea that development is through patterns of rewards and punishments. • Social learning theory's idea that development is through observation of others.